

Understanding Emotional Signals at Work

Why this matters:

Emotions are not the problem, they are information

Emotions can influence:

- communication
- decision-making
- collaboration
- conflict resolution
- professional reputation

By interpreting emotions we can:

- have better judgement
- greater self-control
- stronger relationships
- improved accountability

The Brain's Three Layers

1. Brain Stem ("Reptile Brain")

- controls survival function (breathing, heart rate)
- activates flight, fight or freeze

2. Limbic System ("Emotional Brain")

- process emotion
- forms emotional memories
- includes the amygdala

3. Neo Cortex ("Thinking Brain")

- reasoning and analysis
- planning and decision-making
- language and impulse control

Amygdala hijack: when the amygdala perceives danger, it can override logical thinking.

Stress vs Pressure

Stress:

- internal
- fears, doubts, insecurity
- unique to the individual

Pressure:

- external
- deadlines, expectations, performance demands
- often shared across teams



Negativity Bias

Our brains are wired to:

- notice criticism faster than praise
- assume threat before safety
- prepare for worse-case outcomes

Bias that once supported survival can now lead to:

- catastrophizing
- misreading tone
- overreacting to feedback
- assuming negative intent

Reacting vs Responding

Reacting may look like:

- sending a tense email
- interrupting
- shutting down
- raising your voice
- defensive posture

Responding may look like:

- pausing before speaking
- naming the emotion
- checking assumptions
- asking clarifying questions
- choosing professional language



Emotional Signals Are Not Universal

Includes:

- direct eye contact
- silence
- loud enthusiasm
- reserved tone

Note: These may signal different emotions depending on cultural norms

Responsibility vs Accountability

Responsibility

- assigned duties
- can be delegated
- appears in job descriptions

Accountability

- owning outcomes
- can't be delegated
- may require emotional maturity
- often occurs after action



Instead of Flight, Fight or Freeze

Practice: Regroup, Reflect and Respond